

The Heart of the Noble Immeasurable Life and Wisdom Dhāraṇī

Ārya Aparimitāyurjñānaḥṛdaya nāma dhāraṇī · Toh 676 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཚེ་དང་ཡ་ཤེས་དཔག་ཏུ་མཉེན་པོ་སྒྲིབ་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའ་གི་ཟུང་སྟེང་།

Toh 676 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Aparimitāyurjñānaḥṛdaya nāma dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as the dhāraṇī called "The Heart of the Noble Immeasurable Life and Wisdom." It belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur and is concerned with the theme of immeasurable life and wisdom, centered on the buddha Amitāyus and the western pure realm of Bliss. The text is framed as a discourse delivered by the Buddha to an assembly of monks and bodhisattvas beside the Gaṅgā, and it incorporates both verse and prose to convey its sacred teachings and protective formulae. As a dhāraṇī sūtra, it combines canonical narrative framing with the presentation of a potent ritual formula, placing it among the scriptural collections dedicated to the recitation and preservation of enlightened qualities.

The world, together with gods and all beings, rejoiced, and praised what the Blessed One had spoken. Here ends the noble dhāraṇī of Immeasurable Life and Wisdom.

In the language of India: Ārya Aparimitāyurjñānaḥṛdaya nāma dhāraṇī. In the Tibetan language: The dhāraṇī called "The Heart of the Noble Immeasurable Life and Wisdom."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling beside a pool encircled by the Gaṅgā, together with a great Saṅgha of five hundred monks and a great Saṅgha of bodhisattvas. Then the Blessed One addressed the monks. The monks listened as the Blessed One directed, and the Blessed One spoke to them these words:

To the west of here

lies the world-realm of Bliss.

There dwells a perfectly awakened buddha,
the Tathāgata Amitāyus.

Whoever recites that one's name

shall be reborn in that very place.

At the time of death, the Teacher appears,

attended by the Saṅgha of monks.

There are no women there,
no beings dwelling in a womb;
from lotuses of precious jewels
great miraculous powers arise.

Food, clothing, medicines,
Dharma robes, bedding, and almsbowls —
the very instant the mind conceives of them,
they appear without delay.

The buddhas dwelling in the ten directions
sing the praises of that Bliss;
thus are the buddhas inconceivable,
and the Dharma of the buddhas inconceivable,
and the noble Saṅgha inconceivable.
To have faith in the inconceivable
brings inconceivable karmic maturation:
one is born in a pure field.

O monks, there exists a palace of the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened Amitāyus, together with his retinue, measuring ten thousand leagues in breadth. He was born into the warrior caste (kṣatriya).

O monks, the father of the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened Amitāyus was a wheel-turning king (cakravartin) named Supreme Goodness. His mother was named Resplendent. His queen was named Protectress of the Noble Warrior Clan.

O monks, the son of the Tathāgata Amitāyus was named Moonlight. His attendant was named Pure Fame.

O monks, the foremost among the wise of the Tathāgata Amitāyus was named Crest of Goodness. The foremost among those endowed with miraculous powers and the foremost among those endowed with great diligence was named Great Splendor.

O monks, the māra of the Tathāgata Amitāyus was named King of Offerings. The name of the god Śakra (Indra) was Pure.

O monks, the great assembly of hearers of the Tathāgata Amitāyus comprised sixty thousand great hearers.

O monks, let all sentient beings, with earnest reflection, properly hold the name of the Tathāgata Amitāyus, and for ten days cultivate mindful recollection of the buddha without distraction of mind, keeping always in mind the Tathāgata Amitāyus dwelling in the world-realm of Bliss.

Let them also constantly recite this dhāraṇī called "The Glorious King of the Drum of Deathlessness."

Three times by day and three times by night, prostrating with the five limbs, let all sentient beings meditate upon the Tathāgata Amitāyus; after ten days have passed, they shall behold the Tathāgata Amitāyus. They shall also behold all the blessed buddhas dwelling in the ten directions.

If all their roots of virtue are fully dedicated to the world-realm of Bliss, then at the time of death the Tathāgata Amitāyus shall be present before them, and they shall be born in that Tathāgata Amitāyus's buddha-field.

Monks, what then is the dhāraṇī called "The Glorious King of the Drum of Deathlessness"? It is this:

tadyathā — śabale abale samajale nirdeśe nirjāte nirukte nirmukhe
jvalāvarichedane sukhāvatī-nirdeśe amṛte āyurgarbha-nirāhāṇi amṛte
āyuhprasādhane nirbuddhi ākāśa-nirjāte ākāśa-nirdeśe ākāśa-nirkuśaye
ākāśa-nirdarśane ākāśa-adhiṣṭhāne sukhāvatī-adhiṣṭhāne rūpa-nirdeśe
catvāri-dharma-prasādhane catvāri-ārya-satya-prasādhane
catvāni-mārga-bhāvanā-prasādhane bala-vīrya-prasādhane dharmā-chedane
kuśale kuśala-nirdeśe kuśala-pratiṣṭhāne buddha-kuśale viśuddha-prabhāsa
dharma-karaṇe nirjate nirabbuddhe vimale viraje rājase rasāgre rasāgra-bala
rasāgra adhiṣṭhite kule pratikule vikule dante sudantacitte suprasāntacitte
supraṭiṣṭhite sule-sumukhī dharme ca dharme bale ca bale anuśa abale
buddha-ākāśa-guṇe buddha-ākāśa-niraguṇe amṛta-duṇḍubhi-svare svāhā.

Monks, whatever son or daughter of a family of faithful lineage recites as taught this dhāraṇī called "The Glorious King of the Drum of Deathlessness" — let that person, dressed in clean robes, in a pure and spotless place, make offering of flowers and incense to the Tathāgata Amitāyus. Let them also bear in mind the lotus seat of the awakening ground and the magnificent awakening tree. Having aroused aspiration for these, and having brought forth aspiration and faith, they shall be born in that Tathāgata Amitāyus's buddha-field.

Monks, the king of trees of the Tathāgata Amitāyus is called "The Precious Lotus, Radiant and Resplendent" — a tree replete with flowers and fruits in abundance. Its lotus throne, known as "Pure, Clear, Beautiful, and Endowed with Auspicious Rays," is encircled by many precious gems, and there the Tathāgata Amitāyus is seated. To his right is the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara, lord of vision; to his left is the bodhisattva Mahāsthāmaprāpta, and they are surrounded by an immeasurable assembly of bodhisattvas.

Whatever son or daughter of a faithful lineage is endowed with aspiration, faith, and great devotion shall be born there. On a vast golden ground, they shall be born by miraculous transformation upon great lotuses made of the seven precious substances.

Monks, whatever monk, nun, layman, or laywoman correctly holds the name of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitāyus — for them there shall arise no fear of fire, no fear of water, no fear of poison, no fear of weapons, no fear of yakṣas, and no fear of rākṣasas. The karmic maturation of past actions shall have no hold upon them whatsoever.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, those monks and all those in that fully assembled retinue — gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas together with the world — were filled with joy, and they rejoiced in and praised what the Blessed One had declared.

The noble

Translator's Notes

- The opening sentence closes a preceding dhāraṇī text, and the passage then immediately introduces a new text, the Aparimitāyurjñānaḥṛdaya dhāraṇī, with its own sūtra-style narration. The transition is abrupt in the Tibetan and is preserved as such.

The phrase rendered "prostrating with the five limbs" refers to the traditional full prostration in which both knees, both palms, and the forehead touch the ground — a well-established technical expression in Tibetan ritual literature.

- The dhāraṇī syllables are transliterated from the Tibetan phonetic rendering of Sanskrit. Because dhāraṇīs are sacred sound-formulas whose Sanskrit originals are often corrupt or reconstructed differently across recensions, the transliteration given here follows the Tibetan text closely but regularizes the Sanskrit orthography for intelligibility. Listeners should understand these are liturgical sounds and not syntactically parseable Sanskrit prose.

The bodhisattva name rendered "Mahāsthāmaprāpta" (Tibetan: Mighty One Obtained / Great Power Attained) is the standard Sanskrit equivalent; it does not appear in the Tibetan in Sanskrit form but is clearly identified by the Tibetan epithet meaning "one who has attained great power," and this figure is the traditional attendant of Amitāyus alongside Avalokiteśvara.

- The passage ends mid-phrase, consisting solely of the honorific epithet "noble" (ārya), which

introduces a title not yet completed in the given text. This is a fragment only, likely the opening of a colophon or section heading such as "The Noble [Sūtra of...]."

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.